throughout the country exhorted “The path up from underdevelopment is education,” and “The school plan is your responsibility.”[14] The Museo Nacional de la Campaña de Alfabetización, housed in a former military complex in the outskirts of Havana, commemorates the achievements of the campaign (see Figure 2.1).

Figure 2.1 Literacy Museum in Ciudad Libertad outside of Havana, 2000

Source: Photo by Aviva Chomsky



The literacy campaign, like the massive infusion of resources into education, especially for the rural poor, also invoked José Martí’s “radical ideas for rural, vocational, lyrical, and adult education.” Private schools were closed, and basic, vocational, and technical education was spread to every corner of the country.[15] Urban students were required to spend time working in the countryside. In the 1960s, this took the form of two-week mobilizations for agricultural labor; in the 1970s, urban high school students who wanted to follow the pre-university track were sent to rural boarding schools that combined classroom work with manual labor.

Economic and social marginalization meant that Cuba’s poor had little access to health care before the Revolution. Like wealth and education, health care was concentrated in the urban areas. In January 1960 the new government created the Rural Health Service, establishing rural health